

SCAFFOLD

TEAMS & MEETINGS

FOR INTACT TEAMS

The Three-Question Kickoff

A project kickoff protocol requiring the why, the what, and the how each be answered before work starts. **Ten minutes that prevents the three classic mid-project stalls.**

THE DRAIN

Projects stall in three predictable ways: purpose challenges that surface at the steering meeting, momentum that never establishes, and execution surprises that were visible from day one to anyone who looked. Each stall traces to one orientation's question going unanswered at kickoff.

WHAT THIS TOOL DOES

The protocol asks all three questions, out loud, with the team present, and does not close the kickoff until each has a written answer. It takes minutes when the answers exist and surfaces a project risk immediately when they do not, which is the cheapest possible time to find out.

The three questions

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|---|---|---|
| 1 | Why does this matter, and to whom? | The purpose in two sentences, from the sponsor's mouth if possible. |
| 2 | What does progress look like in two weeks? | The first visible milestone and who is watching for it. |
| 3 | How will the work actually get done? | The mechanism: people, sequence, dependencies, the first three tasks. |

HOW TO USE IT

- 1 **Ask them in order, why first.** Purpose frames progress; progress frames mechanism. The order is the protocol.
- 2 **Write the answers on one page.** The kickoff page becomes the project's header: brief, milestone, mechanism.
- 3 **Treat a missing answer as a finding.** A kickoff that cannot answer one question has located the project's first risk, before it cost anything.
- 4 **Assign each answer a keeper.** One person per question owns noticing when its answer stops being true.

WHAT IT WON'T DO

Three questions are a floor, not a plan; real projects still need the full planning their size demands. The protocol guarantees only that no project starts with one of its three load-bearing questions silently unanswered, which is more protection than most kickoffs provide.

IN THE KIT

Kickoff one-page template

Facilitator script

Keeper assignment card

PAIRS WELL WITH

Tool 35 Orientation-Balanced Agenda · **Tool 21** Five-Question Purpose Brief · **Tool 15** Milestone Backplanning